

Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP)

snapcoalition.org/
Policy Hackathon 2026

Policy <> Track G

Science & R&D Funding Policy

About This Track:

This challenge is part of the Policy Hackathon 2026 G track: Science / R&D Funding. Redesign or defend a federal or state R&D funding mechanism.

Use Case Description:

This challenge asks teams to redesign or defend a federal or state R&D funding mechanism — how science gets funded, who decides, and how success is measured.

Problem Statement:

Redesigning how science gets funded, who decides, and how success is measured.

- Select a focus: NSF/NIH/DOE grant-making reform, indirect-cost-rate policy, basic-vs-applied research balance, research security/foreign-influence rules, or state-level R&D tax credits.
- Map the current funding architecture (agency, appropriations process, peer-review structure).
- Identify a specific inefficiency, gap, or political vulnerability in that architecture.
- Design a reform with an implementation and transition plan.
- Assess impact on research output, workforce pipeline, and national competitiveness.

Possible Approaches:

- Appropriations — a funding reallocation proposal with fiscal notes.
- Process-reform — redesign peer review, grant timelines, or overhead-cost rules.
- Competitiveness — benchmark against China/EU/UK science-funding models.
- Pipeline — center on early-career researcher funding and retention.

Challenge Duration:

- Teams start working in September 2026
- Submission on **November 14, 2026**. There will be no extension to the submission deadline.

Team Guidelines:

- Team size — **3–5 participants per team, interdisciplinary encouraged.**
- Ensure you are enrolled as a participant in Policy Hackathon 2026.
- Everyone is eligible to participate in this challenge and win awards.
- Standout teams may be invited to brief partner organizations or judges directly on their proposal.

Challenge Tasks / Deliverables:

- 4–6 page policy brief with baseline funding data and recommendation
- One-page fact sheet for an appropriations subcommittee audience

- Slide deck (8–10 slides)
- A simple before/after funding-flow diagram
- Process appendix (0.5 page)

Optional Advanced Tasks:

- Interview a researcher or grants administrator (with consent)
- Comparative case study of another country's science-funding model
- A researcher's-eye-view narrative of how the reform changes the grant-application experience
- Draft model appropriations report language

Platforms and Tools:

- Data: NSF NCSES, NIH RePORTER, DOE Office of Science budget documents, AAAS R&D budget tracker
- Legislative tracking: Congress.gov, agency budget justifications
- Drafting/collaboration: Google Docs, shared repo

Judging Criteria:

- Understanding of the funding process — **25%**
- Feasibility (political + administrative) — **20%**
- Impact on research quality/output — **20%**
- Clarity of communication — **20%**
- Originality — **15%**

Data Privacy / Eligibility Restriction:

- Public budget documents and aggregate statistics only — no confidential reviewer deliberations or unpublished proposals.
- Consent and anonymization for any researcher interviews unless attribution is agreed.
- Disclose AI tool use.

Participants retain ownership of their submissions but grant Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP) the right to evaluate, discuss, and showcase submitted work for educational and research purposes, with appropriate attribution.